to settle the South, where they clear the forests and cultivate the land.

The Velirs were historically the members of a royal clan of dynastic kings who were mostly vassals of the more powerful great dynasties of Tamil kings, the Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas, with whom they intermarried over many centuries. There is less certainty over the Aruvalar. According to the late historian K. R. Subramanian, their name was derived from *aruval* or 'billhook' and they were pastoralists who made their homeland in Tondai Nadu or Tondaimallam in what is now northern Tamil Nadu. They appear also to have been known as Aruvar, which Subramanian equated with the Tamil word for Nagas, suggesting that they may have been snake-worshippers. Ptolemy the Elder mentions the Aravarnoi, who had in their country the emporium of Malanga where their king Basaronages resided, neither yet successfully identified.[11] However, another theory equates the Aruvalar with the Vellalars, taking their name from the Tamil *vellam*, 'flood', relating to the flooding of the rice-fields, because these Vellalars were farmers who rose to become a dominant landowning class in early Tamil society, second only in status to the kings, who married their daughters. Today found throughout Tamil Nadu, southern Kerala and Sri Lanka, Vellalars such as the Pillais still play an important role in Tamil society – and still speak of themselves as Gangeyas, or 'children of Mother Ganga', as if they had their origins in the North. Both these groups identify themselves with the Kshatriya warrior caste and with Shaivism.

Having settled these immigrants in the South, the sage Agathya retreats to his hilltop hermitage in the mountains – no longer named Mahendra by this account, but now Pothigai or Pothiyil, quintessentially Tamil words meaning 'a meeting place of knowledge or awakening'. However, Agathya still has more blessings to confer on the Tamil